



Comparatives and Superlatives Podcast

Gate 5 – Terms & Conditions

Welcome to Gate 5

Today we are digging into **travel syntax**.

It is trickier than it sounds.

Mission: Accurately **compare things** in English.

A Super Confusing Word

“**than**”

We will uncover the **hidden mechanics** of one small word.

This little word causes so many errors, especially for **advanced learners**.



Comparing Unlike Things

People fall into the trap of comparing **unlike things**.

Fares in Bangkok are cheaper than Tokyo.

Example: “Fares in Bangkok are cheaper **than Tokyo**.”

This is a very typical **student sentence**.

Pricing Paper Against a City



In that sentence, you literally compare a price to a **physical human being** or city.



You **cannot** price a fare against an entire **physical city** of buildings and streets.

That is just **bizarre logic**.



Balancing the Comparison

To fix it, you must **balance the comparison**.
For plural things like fares, use the word "**those**".

Correct: "Fares in Bangkok are cheaper than **those in Tokyo**."

fares

those

Solution 2

The Simplest Fix

The simplest fix is just reusing the little **direction word**.

This is called the **preposition**.

Correct: "Fares are cheaper **in Bangkok** than **in Tokyo**."

in Bangkok than **in Tokyo**."

Fares are **IN** than in Tokyo.

What "Than" Actually Does

Why do we make this mistake in the first place?

There is a massive misunderstanding of what the word "**than**" actually does.

It does not just **introduce a noun**.

The Deleted Words

It actually introduces a
full grammatical clause.



This is a sentence part with a
verb, but predictable words have
been **deliberately deleted.**



There is a **hidden hole** in
the sentence.

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The Great Argument

This explains a **300-year-old debate** among educated native speakers.

than I

than me

"she travels more **than I**"

"she travels more **than me**"

Viewed as a
conjunction

It depends on if you view it as
a **conjunction** or a **preposition**.

Viewed as a
preposition

Bypassing the Argument

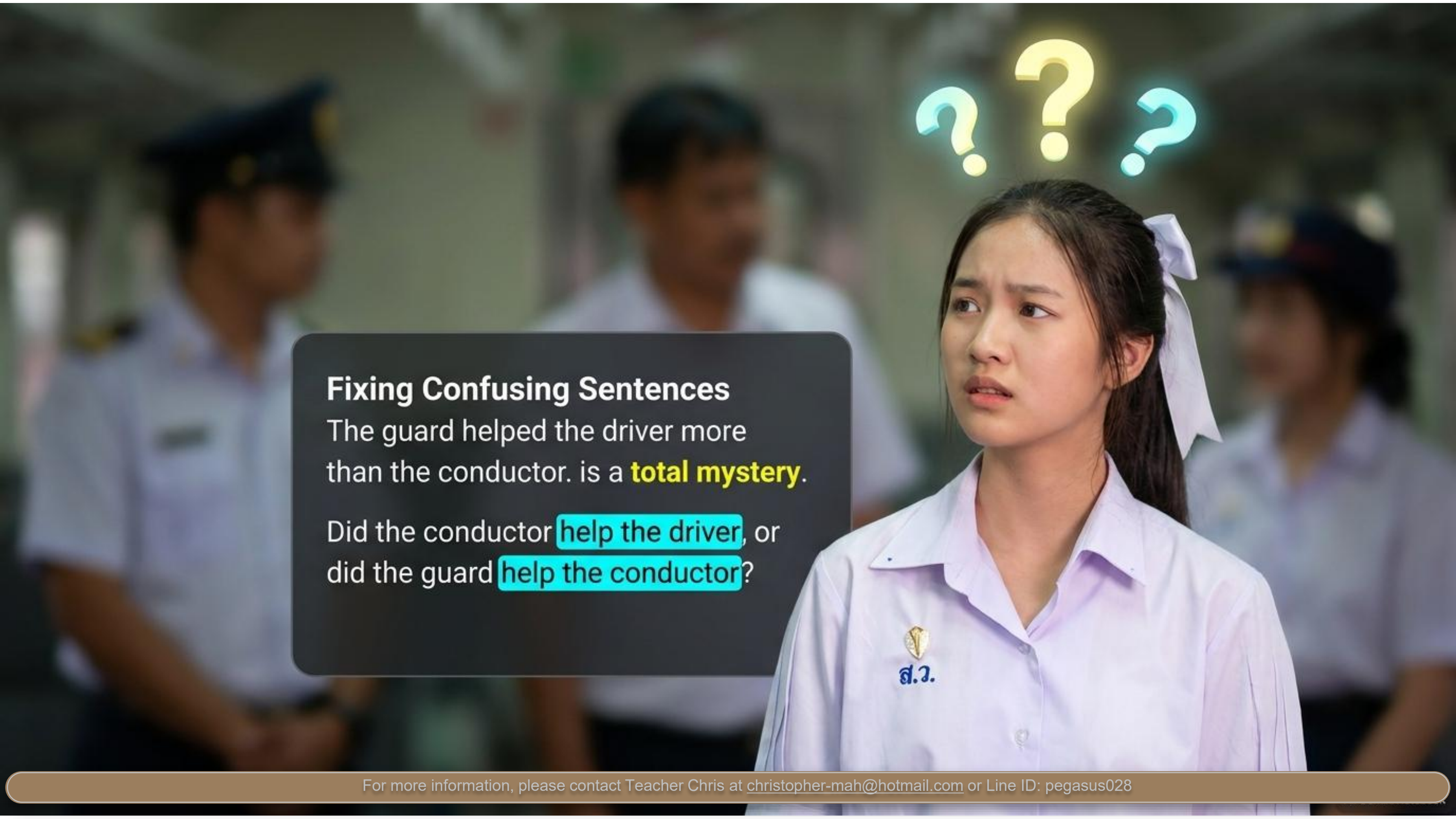
Learners can bypass this whole argument with a **brilliant hack**.

Just **put the missing verb** back.

Instead of arguing, just say:

» "**than I do**"

» "**than she does**"

A young woman with dark hair tied in a ponytail with a white bow, wearing a white school uniform shirt with a gold emblem and the Thai letters 'ส.ว.' on the left chest. She has a confused expression and is looking slightly to the left. Above her head are three glowing question marks: one yellow and two light blue. In the background, there are blurred figures of people in uniform, possibly police or security guards.

Fixing Confusing Sentences

The guard helped the driver more than the conductor. is a **total mystery**.

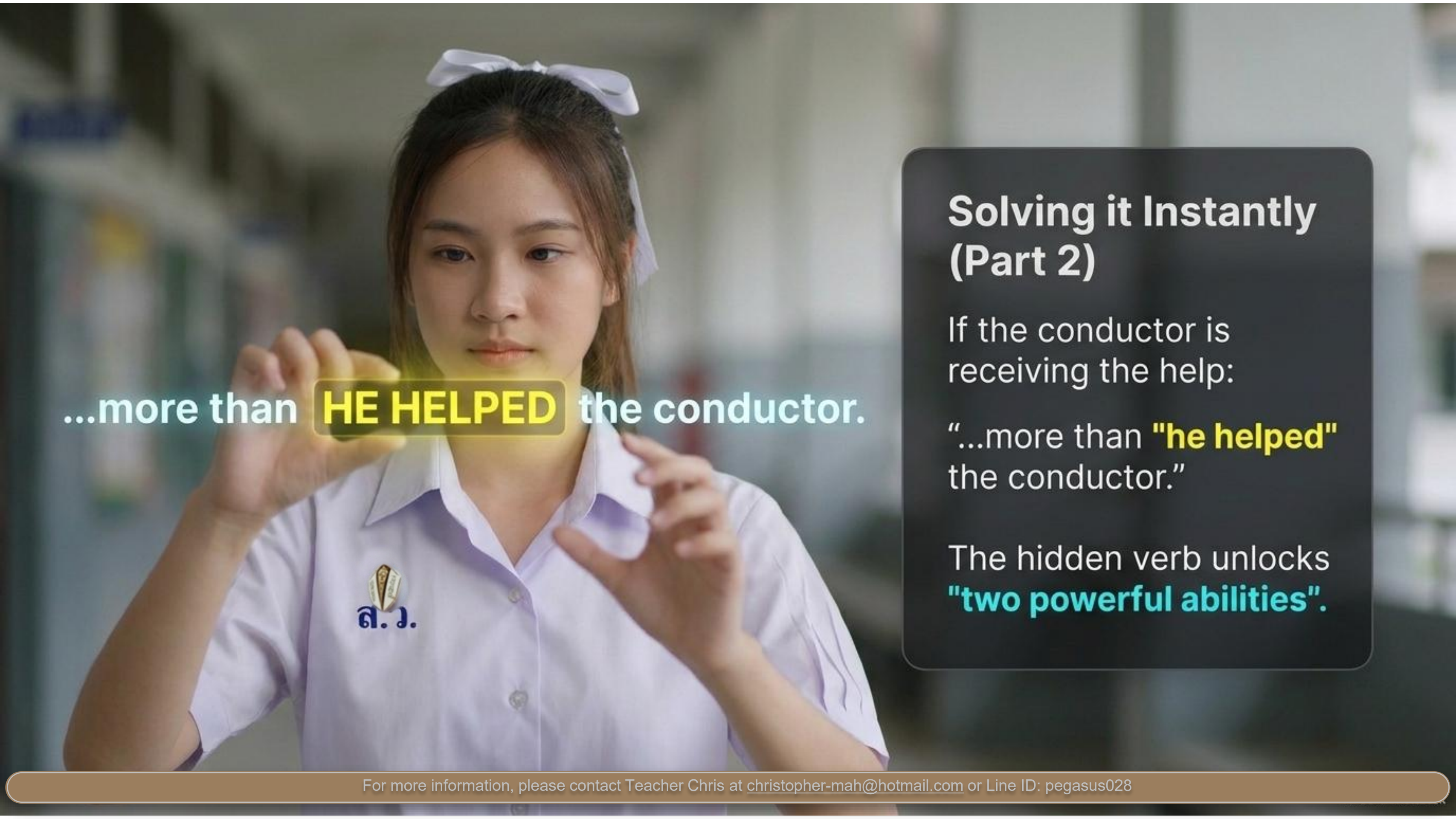
Did the conductor **help the driver**, or
did the guard **help the conductor**?

Solving it Instantly (Part 1)

Putting the **"hidden verb back"** solves it instantly.

If the conductor is doing the helping:
"...**more than the conductor did**".

...more **DID** than the conductor



...more than **HE HELPED** the conductor.

Solving it Instantly (Part 2)

If the conductor is
receiving the help:

“...more than **"he helped"**
the conductor.”

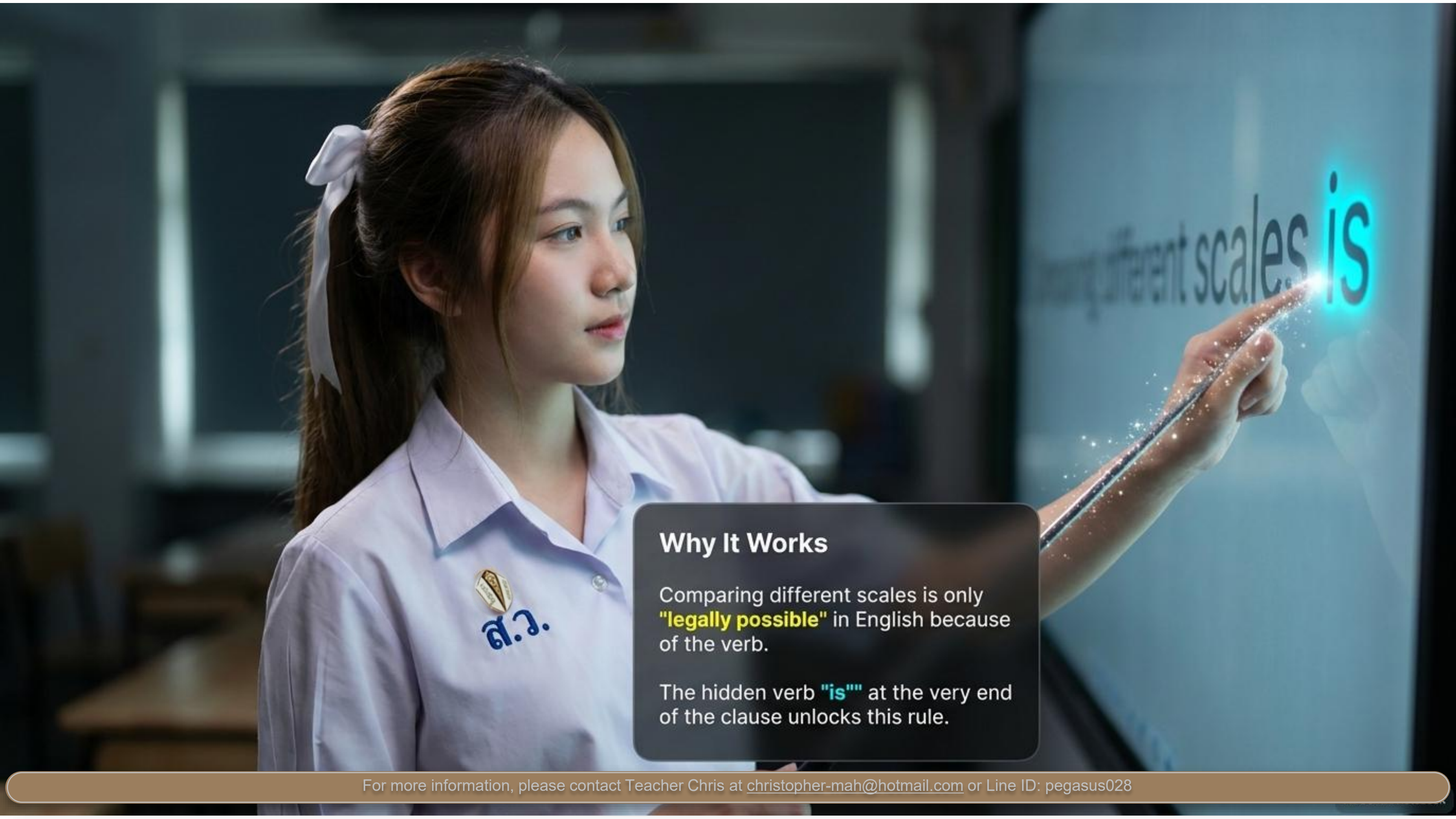
The hidden verb unlocks
"two powerful abilities".

Powerful Ability 1

You can compare **"completely different scales"** of measurement.

Example: "The platform is **"longer"** than the train is **"wide"**."

You are successfully comparing **"length with width"**.



Why It Works

Comparing different scales is only **"legally possible"** in English because of the verb.

The hidden verb **"is"** at the very end of the clause unlocks this rule.

EUPHORIA

MELANCHOLY

QUINTESSENTIAL

SERENDIPITY

ETHEREAL

INEFFABLE

LUMINESCENT

EPIPHANY

Powerful Ability 2

The hidden verb also allows you to **"upgrade your vocabulary"**. Normally, words like "any" and "ever" require a **"negative word"**.

Example: "I **"haven't ever"** been there."

Sounding Confident

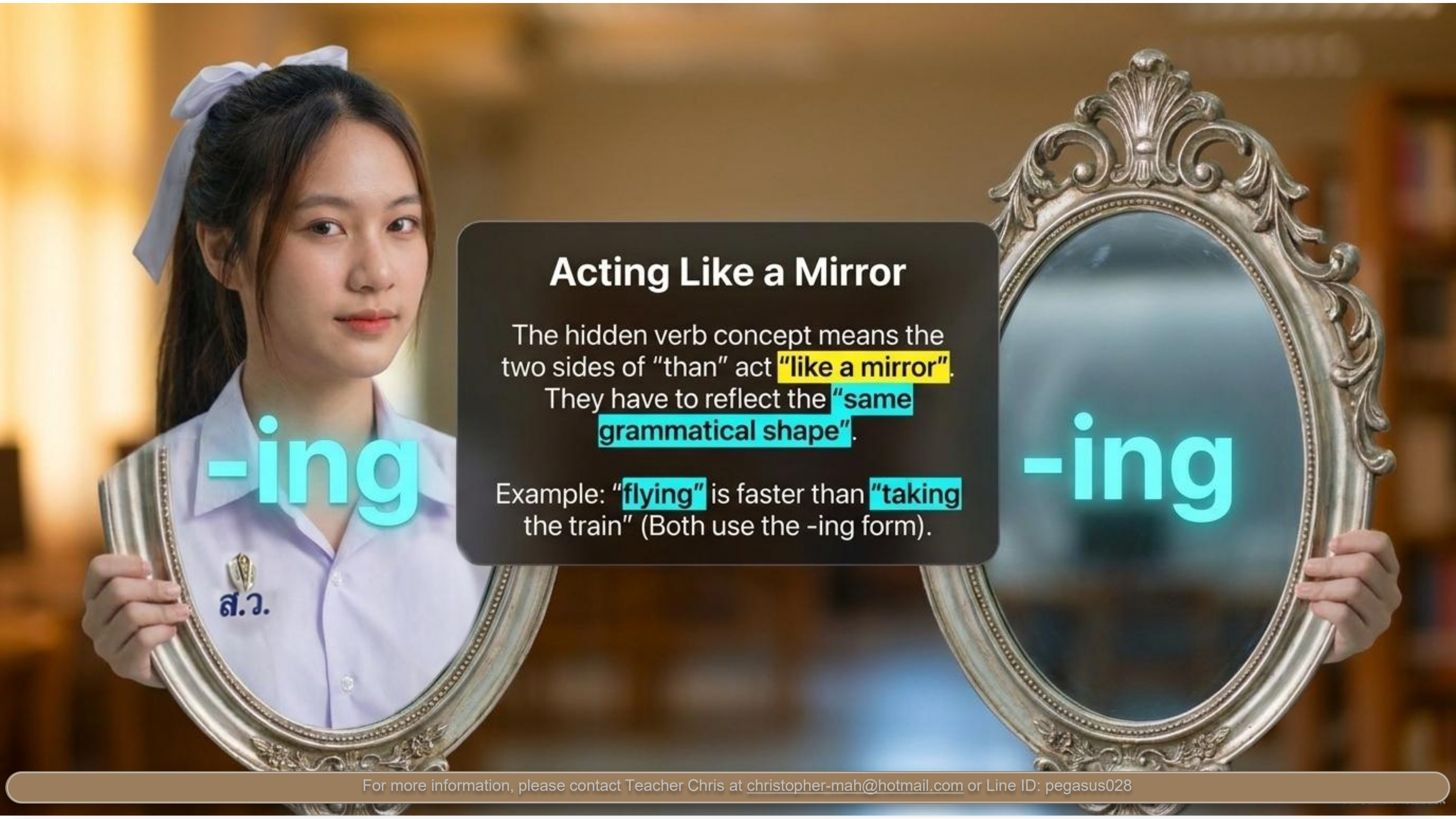
Sounding Confident

Inside a "than" clause, they are
"**completely free from negatives**"

Swap "**faster than**
"**some other**
lines" (weak).

With "**faster than**
"**any other**" line"
(strong and
confident).

ANY



Acting Like a Mirror

The hidden verb concept means the two sides of "than" act **"like a mirror"**. They have to reflect the **"same grammatical shape"**.

Example: **"flying"** is faster than **"taking"** the train" (Both use the -ing form).

-ing

-ing

Matching Structures

If you say "flying is faster than 'to take' the train", you "break the mirror".
The structure "always has to match".

flying

to take



The Golden Rule for 'Than'

If you remember just **'one single rule'**, let it be this: Both sides of **'than'** must be the **'exact same kind of thing'**. Prices with prices, climates with climates, **'people with people'**.